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In the end, the *Top Gun* effect was realized. Shooting the vintage jets in their natural environment gave the sequence the practical imperfections Nelson was after. The master chef had just baked a sumptuous cake for which the CG was merely a layer of icing.

NELSON: "The turbulence as the camera follows the plane is real, the hard light playing off the metallic sides of the jets is real, the ice on the lens is real: We were able to deliver a world that has space and volume."